

Passages - The Antichrist

What is good? All that enhances the feeling of power, the Will to Power, and power itself in man. What is bad? - All that proceeds from weakness. What is happiness? - The feeling that power is increasing - that resistance has been overcome.

Christianity has sided with everything weak, low, and botched; it has made an ideal out of antagonism towards it the self-preservative instincts of strong life: it has corrupted even the reason of the strongest intellects, by teaching that the highest values of intellectuality are sinful, misleading and full of temptations.

Life itself, to my mind, is nothing more nor less than the instinct of growth, of permanence, of accumulating forces, of power: where the will to power is lacking, degeneration sets in.

This depressing and infectious instinct (pity) thwarts those instincts which aim at the preservation and enhancement of the value life: by multiplying misery quite as much as by preserving all that is miserable, it is the principal agent in promoting decadence - pity exhorts people to nothing, to nonentity!

The pathos which grows out of this state, is called faith: that is to say, to shut one's eyes once and for all, in order not to suffer at the sight of incurable filth. People convert this faulty view of all things into a moral, a virtue, a thing of holiness. They endow their distorted vision with a good conscience - they claim that no other point of view is any longer of value, once theirs

has been made sacrosanct with the names 'God', 'Salvation', 'Eternity. I unearthed the instinct of the theologian everywhere: it is the most universal, and actually the most subterranean form of falsity on earth.

A virtue must be our invention, our most personal defence and need: in every other sense it is merely a danger. That which does not constitute a condition of our life, is merely harmful to it: to possess a virtue merely because one happens to respect the concept 'virtue', as Kant would have us do, is pernicious. 'Virtue', 'Duty', 'Goodness in itself, goodness stamped with the character of impersonality and universal validity - these things are mere mental hallucinations, in which decline the final devitalisation of life and Koenigsbergian Chinadom find expression.

What is there that destroys a man more speedily than to work, think, feel, as an automaton of 'duty' without internal promptings, without a profound personal predilection, without joy? This is the recipe par excellence of decadence and even of idiocy

What does a priest care about science! He stands too high for that!- And until now the priest has ruled! - He it was who determined the concept "true and false".

It was our modesty which ran counter to their taste so long

The only purpose served by the old word 'will' is to designate a result, a sort of individual reaction which necessarily follows upon a host of partly discordant and partly harmonious stimuli: the will no longer 'effects' or 'moves' anything . . . Formerly people thought that man's

consciousness, his 'spirit', was a proof of his lofty origin, of his divinity. With the idea of perfecting man, he was conjured to draw his senses inside himself, after the manner of the tortoise, to cut off all relations with terrestrial things, and to divest himself of his mortal shell. Then the most important thing about him, the 'pure spirit', would remain over. Even concerning these things we have improved our standpoint. Consciousness, 'spirit', now seems to us rather a symptom of relative imperfection in the organism, as an experiment, a groping, a misapprehension, an affliction which absorbs an unnecessary quantity of nervous energy. We deny that anything can be done perfectly so long as it is done consciously.

'Pure spirit' is a piece of 'pure stupidity': if we discount the nervous system, the senses and the 'mortal shell', we have miscalculated - that it is all! . . .

What is the only kind of man who has reasons for wriggling out of reality by lies? The man who suffers from reality. But in order to suffer from reality one must be a bungled portion of it. The preponderance of pain over pleasure is the cause of that fictitious morality and religion: but any such preponderance furnishes the formula for decadence.

When he becomes the pauper's God, the sinner's God, the sick man's God par excellence, and the attribute 'Saviour', 'Redeemer', remains over as the one essential attribute of divinity: what does such a metamorphosis, such an abasement of the godhead imply? - Undoubtedly, 'the kingdom of God' has thus become larger. Formerly all he had was his people, his 'chosen' people. Since then he has gone travelling over foreign lands, just

as his people have done; since then he has never rested anywhere: until one day he felt at home everywhere, the Great Cosmopolitan - until he got the 'greatest number', and half the world on his side. But the God of the 'greatest number', the democrat among gods, did not become a proud heathen god notwithstanding: he remained a Jew, he remained the God of the back streets, the God of all dark corners and hovels, of all the unwholesome quarters of the world! . . . His universal empire is now as ever a netherworld empire, an infirmary, a subterranean empire, a ghetto-empire . . . And he himself is so pale, so weak, so decadent . . . Even the palest of the pale were able to master him - our friends the metaphysicians, those albinos of thought. They spun their webs around him so long that ultimately he was hypnotised by their movements and himself became a spider, a metaphysician. Thenceforward he once more began spinning the world out of his inner being - sub specie Spinozae - thenceforward he transfigured himself into something ever thinner and ever more anaemic, became 'ideal', became 'pure spirit, became 'absolutum', and 'thing-in-itself... The decline and fall of a god: God became the 'thing-in-itself'.

This hybrid creature of decay, nonentity, concept and contradiction, in which all the instincts of decadence, all the cowardices and languors of the soul find their sanction!

Christian is the hatred of the intellect, of pride, of courage, freedom, intellectual libertinage, Christian is the hatred of the senses, of the joys of the senses, of joy in general.

If, however, faith is above all necessary, then reason, knowledge, and scientific research must be brought into evil repute: the road to truth becomes the forbidden road.

Love is the state in which man sees things most widely different from what they are. The force of illusion reaches its zenith here, as likewise the sweetening and transfiguring power. When a man is in love he endures more than at other times; he submits to everything.

Chance robbed of its innocence;
unhappiness polluted with the idea of 'sin';
well-being interpreted as a danger, as a
'temptation'; physiological indisposition
poisoned by means of the canker-worm of
conscience

The fatal feature of Christianity lies in the necessary fact that its faith had to become as morbid, base and vulgar as the needs to which it had to minister were morbid, base and vulgar.

Even the priest knows quite as well as everybody else does that there is no longer any 'God', any sinner' or any 'Saviour, and that 'free will', and 'a moral order of the universe' are lies.

The concepts 'Beyond, Last Judgment', immortality of the soul', the 'soul' itself, are merely so many instruments of torture, so many systems of cruelty, on the strength of which the priest became and remained master. Everybody knows this, and nevertheless everything remains as it was.

What an abortion of falsehood modern man must be, in order to be able without a blush still to call himself a Christian!

Buddhism promises little but fulfils more, Christianity promises everything but fulfils nothing.

When the centre of gravity of life is laid, not in life, but in a beyond - in nonentity - life is utterly robbed of its balance. The great lie of personal immortality destroys all reason, all nature in the instincts - everything in the instincts that is beneficent, that promotes life and that is a guarantee of the future, henceforward arouses suspicion. The very meaning of life is now construed as the effort to live in such a way that life no longer has any point . .

Why show any public spirit? Why be grateful for one's origin and one's forebears? Why collaborate with one's fellows, and be confident? Why be concerned about the general weal or strive after it? ... All these things are merely so many 'temptations', so many deviations from the 'straight path'. 'One thing only is necessary.

The Christian is nothing more than an anarchical Jew.

All is cowardice, all is a closing of one's eyes and self-deception.

'Consequently science also comes from woman.'

Moral: science is the most prohibited thing of all - it alone is forbidden. Science is the first, the germ of all sins, the original sin. This alone is morality.

Sin, I repeat, this form of self-pollution par excellence on the part of man, was invented in order to make science, culture and every elevation and noble trait in man

quite impossible; by means of the invention of sin the priest is able to rule.

And when a man goeth through fire for his teaching - what does that prove? Verily, it is more when out of one's own burning springeth one's own teaching.

What is bad? Everything that proceeds from weakness, envy and revenge.

A religious man thinks only of himself.